

MISSION 2036

- At the core of Gujarat's pitch for the 2036 Summer Olympics is the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel Sports Enclave, spread over 215 acres with a proposed built-up area of 9.3 million sq. ft
- Being built in phases along the Sabarmati riverfront in Ahmedabad's Motera, it will cost about Rs 4,600 crore
- It will house venues for 20+ Olympic games, including athletics, football, aquatics, basketball, tennis, hockey, badminton and cycling
- Additional facilities include an Olympics Village, administrative and media offices, hotels, retail stores and food courts
- Will be able to host about 250,000 spectators daily, with parking space for 7,500 cars and 15,000 two-wheelers
- Twenty-two other venues have also been identified for specific games in the twin cities of Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar besides the Polo Forest in North Gujarat and Shivrajpur Beach near Dwarka in Saurashtra

Their unique understanding of the region allows both PM Modi and home minister Amit Shah, who's also the Gandhinagar MP, to take part in the micro-planning. Shah has already held two in-person meetings with Gujarat chief minister Bhupendra Patel besides ministers and officials of the sports and urban development departments to review their preparedness for Ahmedabad-Gandhinagar's Olympics bid, since the BJP's sweeping win in the December 2022 assembly polls.

The BJP's election manifesto included a 'Gujarat Olympics Mission' aimed at creating "world-class sports infrastructure to host the 2036 Olympics". But the work on this mission has been going on for two years, say officials, and a macro urban development plan for Ahmedabad is being prepared with the 2036 Summer Olympics in mind. The twin cities are being developed as an urban agglomeration, and the next Development Plan, due in 2024, will be a joint plan for both cities. Two land parcels have been identified for Olympic Villages, where 7,000 flats are expected to come up to accommodate the athletes and officials. These will be sold in the open market after the Olympics.

Planning is underway with a long-term vision, say officials, to host the Olympics again in a few decades, and other international events, like the Commonwealth Games and Asian Games, in between. The Olympics venue and village will have seamless connectivity with the city and airport through public transport, including the Metro, Bus Rapid Transit System, and the Ahmedabad-Mumbai bullet train. The second phase of the Sabarmati riverfront project is also being planned, with a focus on developing international sporting avenues, particularly water sports.

The twin cities of Ahmedabad and Gandhinagar are being developed with the vision to host the 2036 Olympics and other big sporting events

Currently, the process of engaging international consultants who have prior experience in organising the Olympics is in process. In 2021, PricewaterhouseCoopers came on board to identify potential sites for hosting the Olympics in and around Ahmedabad. Other agencies were also tasked with identifying the facilities to be upgraded within a 100-km radius. Multiple special purpose vehicles are being launched for nuanced planning and execution of the event. Public officials tasked with executing the plan say they are familiarising themselves with the intricacies involved in organising a sporting event of this scale.

That said, these are still early days. There's a whole gamut of procedures before a city is awarded the hosting rights for the quadrennial event. Ahmedabad will have to compete with several cities that are in the arena—Seoul (South Korea), Doha (Qatar), Florence or Turin (Italy), Copenhagen (Denmark) and Toronto-Montreal (Canada), to name a few. But with the level of determination and groundwork on display, Gujarat's chances of bringing the Olympics to India for the first time look quite promising. ■